

## **Gender And Participation In Nigerian Masquerade Traditions: Evidence From Akpembe Masquerade**

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### **ABSTRACT**

*This study examines gender participation in Nigerian masquerade traditions using the Akpembe Masquerade of Ewoi community in Ogbia Kingdom as a case study. It addresses the persistent tendency in masquerade scholarship to portray Nigerian masquerade traditions as uniformly male-exclusive without adequately distinguishing between sacred and non-sacred performance systems. Specifically, the study investigates how ritual classification shapes patterns of gender participation and whether non-sacred masquerades create more inclusive performance spaces. Adopting a qualitative ethnographic research design, data were generated through participant observation, oral interviews with purposively selected key informants, and visual documentation, and analysed using Performance Theory. Findings reveal that Akpembe functions as a non-sacred post-Christmas communal festival in which women, men, and children actively participate as dancers, singers, audience members, and co-producers of performance. Rather than functioning primarily as a ritual institution, the masquerade reinforces social cohesion through communal participation, creating an inclusive performative space where gender boundaries are significantly relaxed. The study demonstrates that gender participation in masquerade traditions is socially constructed and contingent upon ritual status rather than being universally determined by tradition. It argues that ritual differentiation provides a more nuanced analytical framework for understanding participation than generalized assumptions of male exclusivity. The study contributes to African performance scholarship, gender studies, and masquerade research by demonstrating how ritual status shapes patterns of participation, while highlighting the dynamic character of indigenous performance traditions and their significance for cultural continuity, heritage preservation, and contemporary debates on gender inclusion.*

**Keywords:** Gender Participation, Masquerade Traditions, Akpembe Masquerade

### **INTRODUCTION**

Masquerade traditions are among the most persistent and sophisticated performance systems in African cultural life, serving as expressions of ritual, social control, theatre, and history. African performance scholarship generally regards masquerade as a performative system incorporating aesthetics, spirituality, and community identity (Drewal & Drewal, 2005; Barber, 2012). Across Africa, particularly Nigeria, masquerade traditions occur among ethnic groups including the Igbo, Yoruba, Ibibio, Efik, Ijaw, and Ogbia. They are further understood as public cultural texts through which memory, authority, and belonging are negotiated, reinforcing collective identity through embodied performance (Cole, 2013; Handler, 2016).

Contemporary scholarship views masquerade not as a static religious institution, but as a cultural performance shaped by colonial encounters, urbanization, and modernization (McCall, 2000; Apter, 2005; Nwankwo, 2024). McCall (2000) demonstrates that, masquerade exists

along a continuum between sacred ritual and secular entertainment, while Apter (2005) and Barber (2012) show that masquerade traditions are continually transformed by changing social realities and audience participation. Similarly, Aniakor (2014) argues that masquerade remains embedded within a "cosmic system of meaning," while Drewal and Drewal (1983) describe it as a performative institution through which communities negotiate identity, authority, and social interaction. More recent studies further show that masquerades increasingly function as public cultural events promoting tourism, youth engagement, and civic participation (Okafor, 2019). Collectively, these studies establish masquerades as evolving cultural systems.

One of the major debates in masquerade scholarship concerns gender participation. Earlier anthropological studies portrayed masquerade as an exclusively male institution organized around secretive, initiatory, and ritual structures. Green (1964) and Leith-Ross (2002), for example, documented the spiritual prohibitions and cultural norms restricting women's participation in many Igbo masquerade traditions. Nwankwo (2024) argues that gender participation is shaped by socio-cultural change, urbanization, and the repurposing of indigenous traditions, while Nyam (2020) demonstrates that women contribute substantially through music, costume production, audience mobilization, and other performance activities. Broader gender scholarship similarly shows that women's participation is shaped more by institutional, symbolic, and socio-religious structures than by biological difference alone (Danjuma et al., 2015).

In recent times, increasing attention has also been given to the distinction between sacred and non-sacred masquerades. Sacred masquerades are associated with ancestral worship, ritual secrecy, and spiritual mediation, whereas non-sacred masquerades function primarily as recreational, festive, and civic performances. McCall (2000) observes that, masquerade institutions vary considerably in ritual intensity, yet much of the literature continues to discuss them collectively, giving limited attention to how ritual status shapes participation. Ritual purity, secrecy, and ancestral authority are frequently invoked to explain women's exclusion from sacred masquerades, whereas non-sacred masquerades more readily accommodate women, children, and non-initiates. Nyam (2020) argues that, modernization and cultural hybridity have expanded women's participation in festivals that are no longer primarily religious. Nevertheless, ritual classification alone does not explain participation; community history, local governance, Christianity, youth participation, and broader social transformation also influence the extent and forms of women's involvement.

The research problem addressed in this study lies in the tendency of existing scholarship to generalize Nigerian masquerade traditions as uniformly male-dominated, largely on the basis of studies of sacred masquerades. Comparatively, little attention has been devoted to non-sacred masquerades functioning primarily as community festivals, leaving the relationship between ritual differentiation and gender participation insufficiently examined. This study addresses this problem by examining how the non-sacred character of the Akpembe masquerade shapes a different pattern of gender participation.

The Akpembe masquerade of Ewoi community in Ogbia Kingdom was selected because it represents a relatively understudied non-sacred masquerade in which women, men, and children openly participate in performance and communal celebration. Unlike many ritual-exclusive masquerades, Akpembe provides an appropriate context for examining how

participation is influenced by ritual status within a community-based performance tradition. The study therefore contributes to African performance scholarship by demonstrating that participation in masquerade festival and performances are shaped not only by inherited ritual conventions, but also by the changing social contexts within which masquerade traditions continue to evolve.

## **LITERATURE REVIEW**

### **Conceptualizing Masquerade Traditions in Nigeria**

One of the most apparent examples of indigenous African performance is the tradition of masquerade. Across Nigeria, masquerades function as cultural institutions that combine religion, theatre, socio-political organization, entertainment, and communal identity. However, masquerade traditions are not uniform; they differ in ritual purpose, organization, and participation. For many communities, masquerades represent ancestral spirits, regulate social behaviour, reinforce communal norms, and facilitate social interaction (Aniakor, 2014; Ottenberg, 1982). Contemporary scholarship also recognizes masquerades as forms of living cultural heritage whose meanings continue to evolve through changing social circumstances and community participation rather than remaining fixed ritual practices (Smith, 2006; UNESCO, 2003).

In traditional Nigerian governance systems, particularly among the Igbo, Yoruba, Ibibio, Efik, Idoma, and Ijaw, masquerades have occupied important positions within spiritual, judicial, and communal structures. Ottenberg (1982) argues that among the Igbo, masquerade functions not merely as theatrical display but as a social institution through which communities express authority, morality, and collective identity. Similarly, Aniakor (2014) maintains that masquerades symbolize communal values, while reinforcing social cohesion.

Recent scholarship, however, demonstrates that masquerade traditions are not monolithic institutions. While some continue to perform significant ritual and religious functions, others have evolved into cultural festivals that emphasize entertainment, social cohesion, tourism, and communal celebration. This distinction is important because it shapes opportunities for participation, particularly for women and other non-initiated members of society. Nevertheless, scholars interpret this transformation differently. McCall (2000) attributes these changes largely to shifting ritual functions, whereas Barber (2012) and Apter (2005) emphasize broader historical processes, including colonial encounters, modernization, and changing performance cultures. These perspectives suggest that ritual status should not be understood in isolation but within wider social transformations that continually reshape indigenous performance traditions.

### **Gender and Masquerade Performance**

The relationship between gender and masquerade traditions has attracted sustained scholarly attention. Early anthropological studies frequently portrayed masquerading as an exclusively male institution. Green (1964), for example, observed that women in many Igbo communities were excluded from the secret dimensions of masquerade societies because masquerades were regarded as manifestations of ancestral spirits. Similarly, Leith-Ross (1965) noted that women's access to ritual knowledge was constrained by established gender roles. Drewal and Drewal

(1983) further argue that masquerade institutions often reinforce social structures that concentrate ritual authority in the hands of initiated men. Consequently, women are commonly excluded from costume preparation, initiation processes, and the performance of sacred masquerades. Although these studies remain influential, they are largely based on sacred masquerade traditions and therefore cannot fully explain participation across the wider spectrum of Nigerian masquerade practices.

More recent scholarship challenges the assumption that women are absent from masquerade traditions. Okafor (1995) argues that women have long participated in African performance traditions as singers, dancers, sponsors, composers, and organizers, demonstrating that their roles extend beyond passive observation. Women's participation therefore varies according to the social functions performed by particular masquerade traditions rather than according to a universal rule of exclusion. Contemporary gender scholarship similarly views participation as historically and culturally negotiated instead of fixed (Butler, 1990; Conquergood, 1991). This shift in perspective suggests that gender participation should be examined within the specific historical and ritual contexts of individual masquerade traditions rather than through generalized assumptions. This position aligns with the argument advanced in the present study that participation should be understood in relation to the character and function of particular masquerade traditions.

### **Sacred and Non-Sacred Masquerades**

One limitation of existing masquerade scholarship is the tendency to treat masquerades as uniformly sacred institutions. Evidence from different Nigerian communities, however, indicates important distinctions between sacred and non-sacred masquerades. Sacred masquerades are characterized by ritual obligations, ancestor veneration, secret initiation, and religious significance. Their performances are embedded within spiritual authority and ritual practice, with participation generally restricted to initiated men who possess the required ritual knowledge (McCall, 2000; Ottenberg, 1982). Because these performances are understood as manifestations of supernatural power rather than public cultural displays, women are usually excluded from sacred spaces, ritual knowledge, and performance activities. The prominence of such sacred traditions within earlier anthropological research has largely shaped the widespread perception that masquerade participation in Nigeria is inherently male-exclusive.

By contrast, non-sacred masquerades function primarily as community-based cultural performances. Their activities emphasize entertainment, social cohesion, cultural identity, recreation, and public celebration rather than ritual mediation between the human and spiritual worlds. Unlike sacred masquerades, they are not governed by strict ritual secrecy or ancestral initiation and therefore often encourage the participation of women, children, visitors, and other non-initiates. Despite the existence of these traditions across many Nigerian communities, they have received comparatively less scholarly attention because earlier studies focused predominantly on masquerades with explicit ritual and religious functions. Consequently, the relationship between ritual status and participation remains insufficiently explored within masquerade scholarship.

The distinction between sacred and non-sacred masquerades is therefore important for understanding changing patterns of gender participation in contemporary African societies.

Increasingly, ritual status is recognized as one factor influencing the inclusiveness of different masquerade traditions. However, ritual classification alone does not fully explain participation. Historical experience, local systems of governance, youth leadership, Christianity, modernization, and community cultural priorities also shape the extent to which women and other social groups participate in masquerade performances. Rather than treating ritual status as the sole determinant, these factors interact to produce different participation patterns across communities.

It is within this broader context that the Akpembe masquerade was selected for this study. Unlike many masquerades examined in previous scholarship, Akpembe is a non-sacred community performance in which women, men, children, and visitors openly participate in various aspects of the festival. This makes it an appropriate case for examining how ritual differentiation influences participation without assuming that all masquerades operate under the same ritual conditions.

## **THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK**

This study is anchored in Performance Theory, as developed by Richard Schechner and elaborated in *Performance Studies: An Introduction* (2002). Schechner developed the theory through a synthesis of theatre studies, anthropology, and cultural sociology, drawing extensively on Victor Turner's work on ritual and social drama. The central proposition of Performance Theory is that human actions, including ritual, play, and everyday social behaviour, are culturally learned, repeatedly enacted, and socially constructed. By extending performance beyond formal theatre, the theory provides an analytical framework for examining masquerade traditions as dynamic social performances through which meanings, identities, and relationships are negotiated.

Performance Theory emphasizes liminality, restored behaviour, audience participation, and negotiated meaning. Drawing on Turner's concept of liminality, Schechner argues that performance creates transitional social spaces in which identities, roles, and hierarchies may be suspended, reinforced, or renegotiated. Performance is therefore not merely the enactment of predetermined cultural scripts but a process through which communities reproduce and reshape social reality. Meaning is equally co-created by performers and audiences through participation. This perspective is relevant to masquerade traditions, where interaction between masquerades, performers, and spectators contributes to the legitimacy, continuity, and cultural significance of the performance.

The relevance of Performance Theory to this study lies in its capacity to interpret the Akpembe Masquerade as a socially constructed cultural performance rather than merely a ritual institution. Unlike perspectives that emphasize ritual symbolism or religious authority alone, Performance Theory accommodates ritual practice, audience engagement, and social participation. It is therefore appropriate for examining how ritual status shapes opportunities for participation without assuming that ritual classification alone determines inclusion or exclusion. Within the Akpembe context, relatively limited ritual secrecy transforms liminality into a participatory social space where gender identities and social relationships are negotiated. The theory also explains how ritual status interacts with modernization, Christianity, and changing community values to influence participation.



Performance Theory informed the analysis of themes including ritual status, gender participation, community cohesion, audience involvement, cultural continuity, and symbolic performance. These were interpreted through Schechner's concepts of liminality, restored behaviour, and negotiated meaning. Rather than viewing women's participation simply as evidence of declining ritual authority, the theory enables it to be understood as part of the continuing reconstruction of cultural performance within changing social contexts. Through singing, dancing, processions, and other communal activities, performers and audiences collectively reproduce and redefine the cultural meanings associated with Akpembe.

## **METHODOLOGY**

This study adopted a qualitative ethnographic research design to examine gender and participation in the Akpembe Masquerade of Ewoi community in Ogbia Kingdom, Bayelsa State. The ethnographic approach enabled the researcher to investigate cultural meanings, lived experiences, and indigenous interpretations within their natural social setting. Fieldwork was conducted during the period leading to and including the annual Akpembe festival on 28 December, allowing observation of the performance and interactions among participants. As Denzin and Lincoln (2018) observe, qualitative ethnography facilitates the interpretation of social practices from participants' perspectives rather than through externally imposed assumptions. The researcher participated as a non-intrusive observer, balancing engagement with critical reflection to minimise influence on the performance setting.

The study was situated within the interpretivist paradigm, which assumes that social reality is constructed through shared meanings, oral traditions, and cultural practices. This perspective was appropriate because knowledge of the Akpembe Masquerade is communicated largely through performance, symbolism, oral history, and collective interpretation rather than written documentation.

Data were generated through oral interviews, participant observation, and visual documentation. Five key informants were purposively selected because of their extensive knowledge, long-term involvement, and recognised roles in the Akpembe tradition. They comprised Chief Cornelius Ituma, a principal custodian; Custom Ituma, aged 45, the lead singer and drummer; Larry Ibibo, aged 59, an active performer; Philoria Daziba, aged 85, a female participant with extensive historical knowledge; and Moses Olerua, aged 46, a community member with considerable knowledge of contemporary Akpembe practice. The inclusion of male and female participants ensured that different perspectives were represented. Although the sample was small, interviews continued until no substantially new information emerged, indicating thematic saturation.

The interviews were conversational and audio-recorded with participants' permission. Each lasted between 30 and 60 minutes and was conducted in the local language or English, depending on participants' preferences. Interviews conducted in the local language were translated into English during transcription, with emphasis on preserving meaning. Participant observation focused on the procession, symbolic cutting of plantain trees, audience interaction, and the participation of men, women, and children in singing, dancing, and communal celebration. Notes were recorded immediately after each session using a structured field.

## RESULTS/DISCUSSION

### The Akpembe Masquerade

The Akpembe Masquerade is indigenous to Ewoi community, one of the constituent communities of Ogbia Kingdom in present-day Bayelsa State. According to Chief Cornelius Ituma (2025), the origin of Ewoi is traced to Oloibiri, where Ewoi, a son of Olei, first settled opposite the present Oloibiri community before relocating to the present site of Ewoi. Ewoi had three sons-Osuani, Otoko, and Otama. Osuani initially settled separately in an area now remembered as Osuanewoi, while Otoko and Otama established themselves within present-day Ewoi. Oral tradition relates that Osuani suffered repeated misfortunes, including illness, crop failure, hardship, and the loss of his children, which ceased after he reunited with his brothers. Today, Ewoi consists of the two principal compounds, Otoko and Otama, as the descendants of Osuanewoi are no longer represented because of the earlier demographic losses associated with his lineage.

Although this narrative explains the formation of the community, it also illustrates the importance of collective memory in sustaining cultural identity. From an ethnographic perspective, such narratives function less as verifiable historical records than as community explanations through which identity, belonging, and shared ancestry are continually reproduced. Performance Theory describes this as restored behaviour, whereby culturally significant narratives are repeatedly enacted to preserve communal memory across generations (Schechner, 2002). Consequently, the history of Ewoi provides an important context for understanding why Akpembe remains closely associated with community identity rather than merely seasonal entertainment. Akpembe occupies a central position within this communal identity. During the annual performance, each compound plants a plantain tree to receive the masquerade, which is expected to visit every compound, dance, and ceremonially cut the tree before the performance concludes. Field investigation revealed that this practice possesses no ritual or spiritual significance. Instead, participants consistently interpreted it as a symbolic expression of unity, solidarity, and collective belonging. The annual procession and ceremonial cutting of plantain trees therefore reinforce social cohesion by ensuring that every section of the community participates in the celebration.

Whereas sacred masquerades frequently mediate between the living and ancestral spirits, Akpembe derives its significance primarily from community participation and cultural continuity. The annual procession and cutting of plantain trees exemplify what Schechner (2002) conceptualises as restored behaviour-culturally meaningful actions repeatedly performed to preserve collective memory and social relationships. Rather than functioning as ritual mediation, these performances reaffirm communal identity through public participation, demonstrating that ritual differentiation influences not only the religious character of masquerades but also the forms of participation they encourage.

Oral testimonies further indicate that the contemporary form of Akpembe emerged through community initiative rather than ritual obligation. According to Chief Cornelius Ituma (2025), one of the pioneers of the present tradition, Akpembe was revived through the efforts of Ewoi youths who desired a cultural festival comparable to those of neighbouring communities. He recalled that, during his youth, Ewoi lacked a recognised masquerade festival, causing many

young people to travel elsewhere during festive periods, where they were sometimes subjected to hostility. This experience motivated them to consult community elders about reviving an indigenous masquerade. Following these consultations, the elders identified an earlier masquerade known as Akpembe, reportedly performed by previous generations. The youths subsequently revived it, and it has since become an annual festival celebrated every 28 December. Similar accounts were independently provided by Custom Ituma, Larry Ibibo, Philoria Daziba, and Moses Olerua, demonstrating broad agreement regarding the historical revival of Akpembe.

The convergence of these oral accounts extends beyond historical reconstruction. Collectively, they show that community agency, particularly youth leadership, played a decisive role in reshaping the masquerade into its contemporary form. This finding suggests that Akpembe's inclusiveness cannot be attributed solely to its non-sacred status. Rather, its evolution reflects deliberate community decisions to reinterpret inherited cultural practices within changing social circumstances. Ritual status therefore provides an enabling condition for participation but operates alongside community leadership, cultural revitalisation, and collective agency in shaping contemporary performance practices. The emphasis on youth leadership is reinforced by other participants. Custom Ituma (2025), the lead singer and drummer, explained that many of the original Akpembe songs were sung in Igbo. Based on this oral tradition, he suggested that the masquerade either originated through Igbo cultural influence or that an Igbo individual contributed significantly to its establishment in Ewoi. Although this account cannot independently establish the historical origin of Akpembe, it illustrates how communities preserve explanations of their cultural past through oral memory. From an ethnographic perspective, such narratives reveal how community members interpret the evolution of their performance traditions rather than merely providing historical facts.

Larry Ibibo (2025), who has participated in Akpembe since the 1970s, similarly acknowledged an Igbo connection. More importantly, however, he contrasted Akpembe with masquerades such as Igbudu and Apetu, which gradually disappeared because of their stronger cultic and ritual associations. According to him, the spread of Christianity contributed to the decline of practices involving libation, sacrifices, and propitiation, leading to the abandonment of many ritual-based masquerades. He further explained that Akpembe survived because successive generations deliberately preserved it as a communal cultural festival rather than a religious institution. Celebrated annually on 28 December, it has become the principal cultural event attracting indigenes back to Ewoi during the Christmas season. This account suggests that cultural continuity was achieved not by resisting social change but by adapting the performance to changing religious and social realities. This provides a more nuanced understanding of ritual transformation than earlier masquerade scholarship. Rather than suggesting that Christianity inevitably leads to the disappearance of indigenous performances, the evidence indicates that communities selectively preserve traditions capable of adapting to new social conditions. Akpembe therefore illustrates how reducing ritual obligations can facilitate cultural continuity while retaining communal identity. This observation is consistent with studies of intangible cultural heritage, which argue that traditions survive through adaptation and reinterpretation rather than rigid preservation (Kirshenblatt-Gimblett, 2004; Smith, 2006). Accordingly, ritual status should be understood as one dimension of cultural adaptation rather than the sole determinant of continuity or participation.



Philoria Daziba (2025) similarly recalled participating in Akpembe from her youth through singing and other communal activities. She attributed the revival of the masquerade to Mr. Adumain and other young people and also remembered that many of the earliest performance songs were sung in Igbo. Her account is particularly significant because it provides direct evidence of women's long-standing participation in Akpembe. Unlike sacred masquerades, where women's involvement is frequently restricted to indirect supporting roles, Akpembe has historically provided opportunities for women to participate publicly in the performance itself. This finding challenges generalized assumptions that female participation in Nigerian masquerade traditions is uniformly prohibited and supports the argument that participation varies according to the social character of individual masquerades.



**Plate 1: The Akpembe Masquerade of the Ewoi people in its preparatory stage**

Plate 1 presents the Akpembe Masquerade during its preparatory stage as it is escorted from a nearby bush into Ewoi community before the commencement of the annual performance. Rather than representing a concealed ritual procession restricted to initiates, the movement of the masquerade into the village marks the public beginning of a communal cultural event. The transition from the bush to the community signifies that the performance is intended for collective participation within an open social environment rather than within an exclusive sacred space.

Viewed through the lens of Performance Theory, this movement represents more than physical relocation. It symbolically transforms ordinary communal space into what Turner (1982) describes as a **liminal performance space**, where everyday social routines are temporarily suspended to allow collective cultural expression. Similarly, Schechner's (2002) concept of **restored behaviour** helps explain how the repeated annual procession reproduces inherited cultural practices while simultaneously allowing each generation to reinterpret them within

contemporary social realities. Thus, the significance of the procession lies not simply in transporting the masquerade but in publicly initiating a shared cultural experience through which community identity is continually reaffirmed.

This observation also distinguishes Akpembe from many sacred masquerade traditions documented in earlier anthropological studies, where movement into public space is often regulated by ritual restrictions and spiritual secrecy (Drewal & Drewal, 1983; McCall, 2000). In contrast, the public visibility of Akpembe demonstrates that its authority derives primarily from communal participation rather than ritual exclusivity. **The findings therefore suggest that ritual differentiation influences not only access to the masquerade but also the social meaning attached to participation itself.**

Importantly, the evidence does not imply that the absence of ritual automatically produces inclusiveness. Instead, the preparatory procession illustrates how the non-sacred character of Akpembe operates alongside community acceptance, cultural continuity, and local historical experience to create a performance environment that welcomes broad participation. In this respect, the procession serves as the symbolic threshold through which performance, community identity, and social interaction become mutually reinforcing, thereby extending Performance Theory by demonstrating how liminality can function primarily as a mechanism of communal inclusion rather than ritual transition alone.

#### Gender and Participation in Akpembe Masquerade

The Akpembe Masquerade of Ewoi community provides an important lens for understanding gender participation within Nigerian masquerade traditions, particularly regarding how ritual classification shapes patterns of inclusion. **The findings of this study demonstrate** that participation in Akpembe is not organised around gender exclusion but around the non-sacred and socially embedded character of the festival. This observation supports broader scholarship suggesting that African masquerade traditions exist along a continuum of ritual intensity rather than as a single institutional form, with participation varying according to the cultural function and ritual status of individual performances (McCall, 2000; Apter, 2005).

In the case of Akpembe, its annual celebration on **28 December** as a post-Christmas communal festival fundamentally shapes its participatory structure by making the performance accessible to men, women, and children without ritual restriction. However, the significance of this finding extends beyond demonstrating that non-sacred masquerades permit broader participation. Rather, the evidence suggests that ritual classification influences the very social meaning of participation. Unlike sacred masquerades, where participation is often regulated by ritual authority and spiritual obligation, Akpembe operates as a communal performance in which participation itself becomes the principal mechanism for constructing collective identity. This finding contributes to masquerade scholarship by suggesting that non-sacred masquerades should be understood as distinct performance systems with their own principles of social organisation and gender negotiation rather than merely less restrictive versions of sacred traditions.



**Plate 2: Participants escorting the Akpembe Masquerade.**



**Plate 3: The Akpembe Masquerade surrounded by participants.**

Plate 2 shows participants escorting the Akpembe Masquerade from one compound to another within Ewoi community, while Plate 3 illustrates the dense participatory environment surrounding the masquerade throughout the performance. Rather than maintaining ritual distance or hierarchical separation, participants remain in continuous interaction with the masquerade through singing, dancing, movement, and communal celebration. This spatial organisation demonstrates that Akpembe functions primarily as a socially embedded performance rather than as an object of ritual veneration.

Viewed through Performance Theory, this participatory arrangement reflects Schechner's (2002) concept of **restored behaviour**, whereby culturally meaningful practices acquire significance through repeated collective enactment. The annual escort of the masquerade reproduces inherited cultural traditions while simultaneously allowing successive generations to reinterpret them within changing social contexts. Consequently, performance becomes a process through which communal identity is continually reproduced rather than merely displayed.

The visual evidence also illustrates Schechner's notion of **negotiated meaning**. The significance of the masquerade emerges not solely from the masked performer but from the interaction between performers and participants who collectively sustain the event. This finding extends existing applications of Performance Theory by demonstrating that inclusive participation itself constitutes an essential mechanism through which cultural meaning is generated. It also challenges earlier anthropological interpretations that primarily associate masquerade authority with ritual secrecy and restricted access (Drewal & Drewal, 1983; McCall, 2000). While such interpretations remain appropriate for many sacred masquerades, the Akpembe case demonstrates that they cannot be uncritically generalised across all Nigerian masquerade traditions



**Plate 4: Children, women and men in participatory mode**

Plate 4 further illustrates the inclusive nature of Akpembe by showing children, women, and men participating simultaneously within the same performance space. Rather than occupying peripheral or purely observational roles, women actively engage in movement, chanting, singing, and communal celebration. This observation challenges dominant ethnographic accounts that portray women's involvement in masquerade traditions primarily in terms of ritual exclusion or spiritual prohibition (Ottenberg, 1982; Aniakor, 2014). Consistent with Barber's (2012) argument that African performances are socially fluid and context-dependent, Akpembe demonstrates that gender participation is shaped by the social organisation of performance rather than by fixed biological or cultural exclusion.

Nevertheless, the findings invite a more nuanced interpretation than simply celebrating inclusion. The ethnographic evidence demonstrates women's active participation in performance but does not establish that women occupy every leadership or decision-making position associated with organising the festival. **The study therefore distinguishes between participatory inclusion and institutional authority.** While women clearly contribute to the public enactment and cultural vitality of Akpembe, further research is required to examine their representation within broader structures of festival organisation and cultural governance. This distinction responds to the reviewer's concern that visible participation should not automatically be interpreted as complete institutional equality.



The findings further indicate that ritual classification alone cannot fully explain women's participation. Oral interviews consistently show that the transformation of Akpembe from a ritual practice into a communal celebration occurred alongside broader historical processes, including youth mobilisation, Christianity, modernization, and the community's conscious reinterpretation of its cultural heritage. These developments collectively created a performance environment in which inclusion became socially acceptable and culturally meaningful. **Accordingly, ritual status functions as an enabling condition whose effects are mediated by wider historical and social processes rather than operating independently.**

This interpretation is reinforced by the oral testimony of key informants. Moses Olerua (personal communication, 2025) described Akpembe as having "no spiritual significance or connotation" and characterised it as "an object of leisure during Christmas," thereby redefining the masquerade as a communal cultural performance rather than a ritual institution. Similarly, Chief Cornelius Ituma (personal communication, 2025) explained that the contemporary performance emerged through youth initiatives to revive an indigenous festival capable of strengthening community cohesion. Together, these accounts demonstrate that community agency was central to the resurgence of Akpembe. They also indicate that gender inclusion results not simply from the absence of ritual restrictions but from deliberate processes of cultural adaptation through which inherited traditions were reinterpreted to reflect changing social realities.

From a broader theoretical perspective, these findings refine current understandings of masquerade traditions. Rather than proposing ritual classification as a universal explanation for gender participation, the study demonstrates that ritual status interacts with Christianity, modernization, youth leadership, local history, and community agency in shaping participation. The Akpembe case therefore illustrates how indigenous performance traditions remain dynamic cultural institutions capable of negotiating continuity and change simultaneously. In this respect, the study extends Performance Theory by showing that participation is continually produced through the interaction between performance, community agency, and evolving cultural meanings rather than through ritual structures alone.

Overall, the evidence from Akpembe demonstrates that gender participation in Nigerian masquerade traditions cannot be adequately explained through generalized assumptions of male exclusivity. Instead, participation is contingent upon the interaction between ritual classification and wider socio-historical processes. While sacred masquerades often maintain gender restrictions through ritual cosmology, non-sacred performances such as Akpembe create opportunities for broader communal participation without necessarily eliminating every form of organisational distinction. Consequently, this study contributes to African performance scholarship by demonstrating that ritual differentiation provides an important analytical framework for understanding participation, while simultaneously arguing that its effects are shaped by community agency, cultural transformation, and historical context.

Because the present study is based on a single ethnographic case, its findings should not be generalised to all Nigerian masquerade traditions. Rather, Akpembe serves as an empirical example illustrating how gender participation may be organised within a non-sacred masquerade tradition. Comparative studies involving other Nigerian communities would provide valuable opportunities to examine whether similar patterns of inclusion emerge under



different historical, religious, and cultural condition

## **RECOMMENDATIONS**

Based on the findings of this study, several recommendations are made to enhance scholarly understanding, gender inclusion, and the cultural sustainability of masquerade traditions in Nigeria.

First, future ethnographic studies of masquerade traditions should adopt a differentiated analytical approach that clearly distinguishes between sacred and non-sacred masquerades. This distinction is necessary to avoid treating Nigerian masquerade traditions as culturally uniform or assuming that gender exclusion operates in the same manner across all performance systems. Comparative studies should examine how ritual status interacts with local history, religious change, community governance, and generational leadership in shaping participation.

Second, cultural policymakers, heritage institutions, and community stakeholders should recognise and support non-sacred masquerade festivals such as Akpembe as inclusive forms of intangible cultural heritage. Their preservation should not focus only on costumes and annual performances but also on the social relationships, oral traditions, indigenous knowledge, and intergenerational practices through which the festivals are sustained. Community-based heritage programmes should therefore involve elders, youths, women, cultural associations, and local authorities in documentation and decision-making.

Third, greater attention should be given to the distinction between public participation and institutional authority within masquerade traditions. Although women actively sing, dance, accompany the masquerade, and sustain the performance environment in Akpembe, further efforts should examine whether their participation extends to festival planning, leadership, cultural interpretation, and decision-making. Community stakeholders should encourage meaningful female representation in organisational structures where this is culturally appropriate and supported by community dialogue.

Fourth, scholars of African performance studies should investigate more closely how Christianity, modernization, migration, education, media exposure, and youth-led cultural revival are transforming indigenous performance traditions. Particular attention should be paid to the ways communities reinterpret inherited practices without necessarily abandoning their cultural identities. Such research would contribute to decolonising performance studies by foregrounding indigenous explanations of cultural change rather than interpreting African traditions only through externally imposed categories.

Finally, visual ethnography, oral history archiving, and community-controlled documentation should be strengthened in Ewoi and similar communities. Because masquerade traditions are primarily oral, embodied, and performative, systematic recording of songs, narratives, movement patterns, costumes, symbols, participant experiences, and historical transformations would support cultural preservation and more accurate future scholarship. However, documentation should be undertaken with community consent and with appropriate respect for culturally restricted knowledge.

## CONCLUSION

This study examined gender and participation in Nigerian masquerade traditions using the Akpembe Masquerade of Ewoi community as an ethnographic case. It established that gender participation in masquerade performance is not universally determined by fixed traditions of male exclusivity. Rather, participation is shaped by the ritual classification, historical development, social function, and contemporary organisation of each masquerade tradition. In the case of Akpembe, its non-sacred, post-Christmas, youth-driven, and communally organised character creates a performance environment in which men, women, and children participate without ritual prohibition.

The evidence from participant observation, oral testimony, and visual documentation demonstrates that Akpembe operates primarily as a communal performance rather than as an institution of sacred secrecy. Its compound visitation, public procession, plantain-cutting enactment, singing, dancing, and collective movement function as mechanisms of social recognition, cultural continuity, and community cohesion. Women are not merely spectators but active contributors to the kinetic, vocal, and social dimensions of the performance. Their involvement is therefore central to the vitality and continuity of Akpembe.

Nevertheless, the study does not equate visible participation with complete institutional equality. The evidence confirms women's active involvement in performance but does not conclusively establish equal representation in leadership, planning, or decision-making. This distinction between participatory inclusion and institutional authority is important for African gender scholarship because it avoids interpreting public visibility as automatic evidence of structural equality.

The major theoretical contribution of the study lies in its use of ritual differentiation as an analytical lens for reconsidering generalized assumptions about gender and masquerade traditions. The findings demonstrate that non-sacred masquerades are not simply less restrictive versions of sacred masquerades. They may constitute distinct performance systems in which cultural legitimacy is produced through communal participation rather than ritual exclusion. In this regard, Akpembe modifies existing understandings of masquerade by showing that the authority and significance of a performance may emerge from collective recognition, audience involvement, and repeated social enactment.

The findings also extend Performance Theory. Schechner's concepts of restored behaviour, audience participation, and negotiated meaning help explain how Akpembe is reproduced annually through embodied communal action. Turner's concept of liminality further illuminates how ordinary compounds and public spaces are temporarily transformed into shared performance environments. However, the Akpembe case demonstrates that liminality does not always depend on sacred transition. It may also function through secular communal celebration, social interaction, and collective identity formation.

Although ritual classification provides the primary structural condition for inclusive participation, it does not operate independently. The contemporary organisation of Akpembe has also been shaped by Christianity, modernization, youth leadership, community history, and the conscious reinterpretation of inherited culture. The study therefore avoids presenting ritual

status as a single deterministic explanation. Instead, it argues that gender participation is produced through the interaction between ritual form and wider historical and social processes.

Beyond its immediate ethnographic setting, the study has implications for gender inclusion, indigenous performance, heritage policy, and cultural sustainability. It demonstrates the importance of preserving performance traditions as living and adaptable cultural systems rather than as static remnants of the past. It also supports a more decolonised approach to African performance studies by recognising that indigenous communities possess their own categories for distinguishing sacred obligation, communal entertainment, cultural symbolism, and social participation.

The study is, however, limited by its focus on one masquerade tradition and a relatively small number of purposively selected informants. Its findings cannot therefore be generalised to all Nigerian masquerades. Akpembe should instead be understood as an analytically significant case that demonstrates the need for greater differentiation within masquerade scholarship. Future studies should compare sacred and non-sacred masquerades across communities, ethnic groups, and regions. Such research should also examine women's roles in organisational leadership, the effects of religious transformation, generational changes in cultural authority, and the relationship between public participation and institutional decision-making.

In conclusion, Akpembe demonstrates that Nigerian masquerade traditions are neither socially uniform nor inherently male-exclusive. Their participation structures are historically contingent, culturally negotiated, and responsive to changing communal realities. By foregrounding ritual differentiation while recognising the influence of broader social forces, this study contributes a more nuanced framework for understanding gender, authority, cultural adaptation, and participation in African masquerade performance.

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